

Common Data Set 2025-2026

Welcome to the 2025-2026 Common Data Set collection!

The **Common Data Set (CDS)** initiative is a collaborative effort among data providers in the higher education community and publishers as represented by the **College Board**, **Peterson's**, and **U.S. News & World Report**. The combined goal of this collaboration is to improve the quality and accuracy of information provided to all involved in a student's transition into higher education, as well as to reduce the reporting burden on data providers.

The CDS is a set of standards and definitions of data items rather than a survey instrument or set of data represented in a database. Each of the higher education surveys conducted by the participating publishers incorporates items from the CDS as well as unique items proprietary to each publisher. Consequently, the publishers' surveys differ in that they utilize varying numbers of items from the CDS.

Those who report data for their colleges are urged to abide by the definitions and the cohorts specified when answering CDS items. They are also urged to use the answers to CDS items when responding to the numerous survey requests they receive, by distributing photocopies of their answers, posting them on their websites, or by other effective means.

This Excel template is designed for CSV export. On each section tab, responses are stored in columns **AA–AL**. Before exporting, verify that your entries appear correctly on the **Answer Sheet**. The Answer Sheet includes field mappings to the **U.S. News fillable PDF** and to the **Word** version. Please confirm with the receiving organization that it is able to accept a CSV of your responses. For more information about the Common Data Set (CDS) initiative, visit <https://commondataset.org/>

Please contact the **College Board College Survey** team at collegesurvey@collegeboard.org should you have any questions about this Excel template.

*Note: At the time of publication, not all questions on the **Excel** template can be matched to a **U.S. News fillable PDF** equivalent. The matching cells for these questions are in light red on the Answer Sheet. Please confirm all questions, responses, and mapping before submitting a CSV to another organization.

*Note: As of publication, some questions in the **Word** template do not map directly—or require different formatting—to an equivalent field in the **U.S. News fillable PDF** and in the **Excel** template. An example are those questions with multiple category options such as "Very Important, Important, Considered, Not Considered". The matching cells for these questions may appear as duplicates (light red on the Answer Sheet) or a single category is listed as the code value (c7_state_residency_very_important). Please review and verify all questions, responses, and mapping requirements before exporting to CSV or submitting to another organization.